Lesson 6 — A Plan for Tuesday

Part 4 of 12: Grammar — the future with will and going to

Level: B1 (sixth step)

About 50 minutes · this part carries a sheet

Come back to: the present perfect

Lesson 4 taught the shape, and for, since, never, already and yet. Two lines to remind you:

I / YOU / WE / THEY	HAVE FINISHED
he / she / it	has finished

New this time: the present perfect and a finished time do not mix.

The present perfect reaches from the past up to now, so it cannot sit beside a time that is closed and gone:

She has submitted the project. ✓ — no time given, and now is what matters
She submitted it on Thursday. ✓ — Thursday is finished, so past simple
She has submitted it on Thursday. ✗ — the two cannot be in one sentence

So an exact date pushes you into the past simple, however recent it is:

WITH A FINISHED TIME → PAST SIMPLE	WITH *FOR* OR *SINCE* → PRESENT PERFECT
They lost three hours last Tuesday.	They have lost three hours this week.
He queued eleven files at six o'clock.	He has queued files since six.
The generator failed at half past seven.	The generator has failed twice this month.

Last Tuesday, at six o'clock, yesterday, in 2023 — all finished, all past simple. This week, today, this month are not finished yet, so the present perfect is still at home in them.

Quick practice. Present perfect, or past simple?

1. The generator _____ (fail) last Tuesday.
2. They _____ (not lose) a single file this month.
3. He _____ (put) eleven files in the queue at six o'clock.
4. Dalia _____ (keep) the list since the first week.

Now the other direction. English has two ordinary ways to talk about the future, and they are not the same: going to looks at a decision that has already been made, and will looks at the moment of speaking.

3.1 How we make them

	FORM	EXAMPLE
going to	am / is / are + going to + verb	She is going to submit it on Thursday.
will	will + verb (no to, no -s)	It will be ready by Wednesday.

Will is the same for everybody: I will, she will, they will. The short form is 'll — I'll, she'll, we'll — and in speech that is almost all you hear. Part 05 is about exactly that.

3.2 Going to: the plan that already exists

Use going to when the decision was taken before you opened your mouth.

> I am going to start the big files at six. — he decided on Sunday
> Nour is going to finish the database work before Thursday. — it is on the list
> We are not going to get more hours. — a fact she has already faced

It is also the future you can see coming, because the evidence is in front of you:

> Look at the battery — it is going to die in ten minutes.
> The sky is black. It is going to rain.

3.3 Will: the moment of speaking

Use will for a decision, an offer, a promise or an opinion made now:

USE	EXAMPLE
Deciding as you speak	The bandwidth is bad — I'll download the small ones instead.
Offering	I'll carry the battery for you.
Promising	It will be ready by Wednesday.
Predicting, or giving an opinion	I think the power will come back at seven.
Refusing (negative)	The old laptop won't start on battery.

Two of those matter most for her: will is what you use when you have just this second decided, and will is what you use for what you think is going to happen, with I think, I am sure, probably, maybe.

3.4 Will or going to?

GOING TO — DECIDED ALREADY	*WILL* — DECIDED NOW, OR ONLY AN OPINION
We are going to plug in both laptops at six.	If the bandwidth is bad, we will take the lectures first.
She is going to submit it on time this week.	I think she will finish before Thursday.
They are going to get better at the hours they have.	Dalia will not say that the plan always works.

A short way to hold it: the list is going to; the conversation is will. Anything written on the door was decided on Sunday. Anything said in the room at six o'clock, while the power comes on and something has gone wrong, is will.

3.5 Negative and question

	GOING TO	*WILL*
Negative	She is not going to ask again.	It will not (won't) start.
Question	Are you going to queue them all?	Will it be ready by Wednesday?
Short answer	Yes, I am. / No, I am not.	Yes, it will. / No, it won't.

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Going to or will? Say why:

1. Look at that battery. It _____ (die) in ten minutes.
2. The bandwidth is bad tonight — I _____ (take) the small files first.
3. It is on the list: we _____ (plug in) both laptops at six.
4. I think the power _____ (come back) at seven.
5. She _____ (submit) it on Thursday. It has been planned for a week.

B. Put the verb in the correct future form:

1. Hani _____ (rebuild) the spare laptop this week.
2. _____ you _____ (download) the lectures tonight?
3. They _____ (not get) more hours of electricity.
4. The project _____ (go) to the cloud before eleven.
5. I am sure the deadline _____ (not move).

C. Present perfect, or past simple?

1. The generator _____ (fail) at half past seven.
2. We _____ (not miss) a deadline this month.
3. He _____ (queue) eleven files last month.
4. Dalia _____ (write) the list every Sunday since October.